GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

1.3 Roads, Railroads, and Canals

MAIN IDEA Between 1800 and 1850, the United States built the most advanced transportation network in the world.



Roads, Railroads, and Canals, c. 1850

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OVERCOMING OBSTACLES

In the early 1800s, Americans moving west and south soon realized they needed more efficient ways to move people and goods across the country. But they faced several geographic challenges. One of these was distance. Today, you can fly from New York City to Miami, Florida, in a few hours. However, in 1800, that trip took three uncomfortable weeks by horse-drawn stagecoach. Travelers called stagecoaches "shake guts" because they shook so much as they rumbled over roads filled with holes and tree stumps.

The Appalachian Mountains represented another geographic challenge. This mountain range stretches north to south for more than 1,500 miles from Canada to Alabama and is up to 300 miles wide. Often steep and densely wooded, the Appalachians formed a physical barrier between the interior regions of the United States and thriving eastern ports such as New York City, Boston, Charleston, and Philadelphia. Americans innovated new solutions and overcame geographic challenges to build an enormous transportation network that produced major economic benefits.

TRANSPORTATION INNOVATION	ECONOMIC BENEFITS
THE NATIONAL ROAD	
During the early years of the United States, the roads were terrible. But in 1811, the federal government built the National Road, also known as the Cumberland Road. The road stretched west from Cumberland, Maryland, to Vandalia, Illinois. A good stretch of it had pavement, making for a much smoother ride. The states charged travelers tolls for their carriages and wagons—and even for their cattle!	The National Road moved mail, goods, and settlers between the East and the growing states of the Northwest Territory, including Ohio, Indiana, and Illinois. The federal government, states, and private companies soon built more roads connecting the East, the South, and the West. Trade expanded between the nation's interior and its bustling port cities, from Boston south to Charleston.
THE B&O RAILROAD	
During the 1820s, merchants in Baltimore, Maryland, struggled to compete with the merchants of New York City, who had the benefit of the Erie Canal to move goods. In 1826, a group of enterprising businessmen founded the Baltimore & Ohio (B&O) Railroad. They needed a steam-operated railroad to connect Baltimore to the growing cities of the interior, such as Cincinnati, Ohio, and St. Louis, Missouri. A steam locomotive called the Tom Thumb ran on the earliest line and proved that steam-powered cars could handle the steep, winding route.	The B&O proved an enormous success. Trains transported coal from the mines of western Virginia and Pennsylvania to the factories and furnaces of the East. The success of the B&O encouraged companies to build other railroads linking states and territories of the East, South, and West. By the 1850s, railroads were carrying all kinds of products. They transported Chesapeake Bay oysters, Florida oranges, and Georgia peaches to the restaurants of New York City. By 1860, the United States had 30,500 miles of track, about as much as the rest of the world.
THE ERIE CANAL	
Americans built a system of constructed waterways called canals that allowed boats and ships to travel inland to move goods. The largest of them, the Erie Canal, connected the Hudson River to the Great Lakes. It cut through 363 miles of land in upstate New York and linked New York City to growing cities such as Buffalo, Cleveland, Detroit, and Chicago.	Building the Erie Canal took eight years. But after it was completed, farmers in Ohio, Illinois, Indiana, and other states in the Midwest could ship their grain much more cheaply and quickly to the East. Before the canal, farmers had to pay $100 per wagon to ship their grain. By using the canal, their cost was only $10 per shipment. Instead of 20 days, the journey took just eight.

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What were some geographic challenges the young United States faced?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Study the map. How did the road, railroad, and canal systems work together as one transportation network?

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